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List of World Chess Championships

The World Chess Championship has taken various forms over time, including both match and tournament play. While the concept of a world champion of chess had already existed for decades, with several events considered by some to have established the world's foremost player, an event explicitly held to decide a world champion did not take place until 1886. World Championships were initially privately organized matches, with each requiring the consent of the incumbent champion to take place. After 1948, the International Chess Federation (FIDE) began organizing the Championship under its auspices. The championship was fixed to a three-year cycle, with each challenger decided by a Candidates Tournament. In 1993, the short-lived Professional Chess Association (PCA) split from FIDE, and as a result there were two competing World Championship titles between 1993 and 2006.



Emanuel Lasker (left) facing incumbent champion Wilhelm Steinitz (right) in Philadelphia during the 1894 World Chess Championship

Key

Date	The year the event took place, further disambiguated as needed
†	Event was a tournament, as opposed to a match.
‡	Event resulted in a draw, with the champion retaining the title.
#	Scheduled event did not take place.
✻	Event began, but was abandoned without any result.
Winner	The winner of the event, or the champion otherwise retaining the title. Numerals denote the updated number of event wins or title defences by the champion.
Score	The performance of the eventual champion. Segments such as tiebreaks are listed sequentially. Head-to-head tournament results are given in a footnote.
Runner-up	The second-place finisher of the event, or the challenger for a match without a winner
Ref	References and footnotes corresponding to the event

Predecessor events (before 1886)

Chess was first introduced to Europe during the 9th century.[1] In the early modern era, following the solidification of the modern rules of chess, the game continued to carry consistent prestige and public interest.[2] While numerous players have been characterized as the game's strongest over the centuries,

the idea of an international chess match or tournament did not occur until the 18th century,[3] and did not materialize until the 19th century.[4] While the following events did not have the title of World Champion at stake, they have been recognized either at the time or in retrospect as indicating the world's leading player.

Date	Location	Winner	Score	Runner-up	Format	Ref
1834	London	Louis de La Bourdonnais	18–7 4–5 6½–5½ 11½–6½ 7½–4½ 4–5	Alexander McDonnell	Casual play	[5]
1843	Paris	Howard Staunton	13–8	Pierre Saint-Amant	First to 11 wins	[6]
1851†	London	Adolf Anderssen	15–6[a]	Marmaduke Wyvill	Single-elimination tournament with 16 players	[7]
1858	Paris	Paul Morphy	8–3	Adolf Anderssen	First to 7 wins	[8]
1862†	London	Adolf Anderssen	11½–1½	Louis Paulsen	Round-robin tournament with 14 players	[9]
1866	London	Wilhelm Steinitz	8–6	Adolf Anderssen	Best of 15	[10]
1883†	London	Johannes Zukertort	22–4	Wilhelm Steinitz	Double round-robin tournament with 14 players	[11]

a. 2½–½ Kieseritzky, 4–2 Szén, 4–1 Staunton, 4½–2½ Wyvill

Privately organized matches (1886–1946)

With both Wilhelm Steinitz and Johannes Zukertort seen as plausible claimants, the two played a match for the first World Championship in 1886. While Steinitz would later claim that he had been the World Champion since the 1860s, no match before 1886 was played for any formal title.[12] From then until after World War II, championship matches were privately organized, and the champion was not formally obliged to face an opponent. An agreement had to be reached between the champion, the challenger, and the patrons sponsoring each match, which included providing the funds for the prize pool.[13] Lasker's 27-year reign as World Champion is the longest in the history of organized chess since 1886, but featured two separate 10-year spans during which he did not defend his title.

Date	Location	Winner	Score	Runner-up	Format	Ref
1886	New York City (1–5), St. Louis (6–9), New Orleans (10–15)	Wilhelm Steinitz	12½ – 7½	Johannes Zukertort	First to 10 wins	[14]
1889	Havana	Wilhelm Steinitz (2)	10½ – 6½	Mikhail Chigorin	Best of 20, tiebreak if required	[15]
1890–1891	New York City	Wilhelm Steinitz (3)	10½ – 8½	Isidor Gunsberg		[16]
1892	Havana	Wilhelm Steinitz (4)	10 – 10 2½ – ½	Mikhail Chigorin		[17]
1894	New York City (1–8), Philadelphia (9–11), Montréal (12–19)	Emanuel Lasker	12 – 7	Wilhelm Steinitz	First to 10 wins	[18]
1896–1897	Moscow	Emanuel Lasker (2)	12½ – 4½	Wilhelm Steinitz		[19]
1907	New York City (1–6, 15), Philadelphia (7–8), Washington, D.C. (9), Baltimore (10), Chicago (11), Memphis (12–14)	Emanuel Lasker (3)	11½ – 3½	Frank Marshall	First to 8 wins	[20]
1908	Düsseldorf (1–4), Munich (5–16)	Emanuel Lasker (4)	10½ – 5½	Siegbert Tarrasch		[21]
Jan–Feb 1910‡	Vienna (1–5), Berlin (6–10)	Emanuel Lasker (5)	5 – 5	Carl Schlechter	Best of 10	[22]
Nov–Dec 1910	Berlin	Emanuel Lasker (6)	9½ – 1½	Dawid Janowski	First to 8 wins	[23]
1921	Havana	José Raúl Capablanca	9 – 5	Emanuel Lasker	Best of 24	[24]
1927	Buenos Aires	Alexander Alekhine	18½ – 15½	José Raúl Capablanca	First to 6 wins	[25]
1929	Wiesbaden (1–8, 24–25), Heidelberg (9–11), Berlin (12–17), The Hague (18–19, 23), Rotterdam (20), Amsterdam (21–22)	Alexander Alekhine (2)	15½ – 9½	Efim Bogoljubow	First to both 6 wins and 15 points	[26]
1934	*12 cities*[A]	Alexander Alekhine (3)	15½ – 10½	Efim Bogoljubow		[27]
1935	*12 cities*[B]	Max Euwe	15½ – 14½	Alexander Alekhine		[28]
1937	*9 cities*[C]	Alexander Alekhine (4)	15½ – 9½	Max Euwe		[29]
Title vacant from 1946 to 1948, following the death of Alekhine.						

A. Baden-Baden (1–3), Villingen (4–5), Freiburg (6–8), Pforzheim (9–10), Stuttgart (11–12), Munich (13–15), Bayreuth (16), Kissingen (17–18), Nuremberg (19–20), Karlsruhe (21), Mannheim (22–24), Berlin (25–26)

B. Amsterdam (1–3, 8–9, 12–13, 18, 20, 23, 25–26, 28–30), The Hague (4, 6, 11, 22, 27), Delft (5, 24), Utrecht (7), Gouda (10), Groningen (14), Baarn (15), 's-Hertogenbosch (16), Eindhoven (17), Zeist (19), Ermelo (21), Zandvoort (26) . Game 26 began on one day in Zandvoort, and was finished on a later day in Amsterdam.

C. The Hague (1, 5, 9–10, 17–18, 25), Rotterdam (2, 7, 15–16, 23–24), Amsterdam (3–4, 12–13, 20–21), Haarlem (6), Leiden (8), Groningen (11), Zwolle (14), Eindhoven (19), Delft (22)

FIDE World Championships (1948–1990)



From right to left: World Champion Anatoly Karpov, former World Champion and FIDE President Max Euwe, and Euwe's wife Caro Bergman. Photo taken in 1976.

In 1946, Alexander Alekhine died while still holding the title of World Chess Champion. The International Chess Federation (FIDE), which had been founded in 1924, had been attempting to directly participate in organizing the World Championship since at least 1935. By the late 1940s, around half of the plausible contenders for the World Championship were Soviet citizens, and in 1947, the Soviet Chess Federation joined FIDE after decades of declining to do so. FIDE based the 1948 World Chess Championship on the 1938 AVRO tournament that had been organized in part to select a challenger for Alekhine. The tournament ultimately featured five players, three of them Soviet citizens—including the winner, Mikhail Botvinnik. Botvinnik went on to win or retain in four further championship matches. At the same time, FIDE established the rules for the championship going forward. It was organized around a 3-year cycle, during which a series of Zonal and Interzonal tournaments were held, with their highest-scoring performers invited to a Candidates Tournament. The winner of the Candidates tournament in turn played the champion in a match for the title. A defeated champion was entitled to a rematch the following year, after which the 3-year cycle would resume. Botvinnik benefited from this rule twice, in 1958 and 1961.[30]

With the exception of the American Bobby Fischer in 1972, Soviet citizens won every championship from 1948 until the dissolution of the Soviet Union in 1991. With the further exception of Viktor Korchnoi, who had defected from the USSR in 1976, each challenger was also a Soviet citizen. Following his victory, Fischer never played another game organized by FIDE. Disagreements between the two parties—which included Fischer's insistence on a format that required the victor to get a certain number of wins, as opposed to the number of games in a match being fixed—led to his forfeiting the title in 1975. In the absence of a match, FIDE declared Anatoly Karpov, winner of the 1974 Candidates Tournament, to be the World Chess Champion by default.[31]

While the issue had played a role in Fischer's forfeit, FIDE ultimately did change the match format going forward, such that the first to win 6 games would be champion.[32] Under these rules, Karpov twice defended his title against Korchnoi. The next match—which began in September 1984 and featured the 21-year-old Garry Kasparov as Karpov's challenger—ultimately saw 48 games played over the span of

five months, with neither player able to get to 6 wins. In an unprecedented step, FIDE president Florencio Campomanes stepped in and declared the match to have ended with no result. A new match, reverted to having a set number of games, was to be played later in 1985. After nearly being knocked out early in 1984, Kasparov defeated Karpov in their rematch. Over the following decade, the two played three more championship matches, with Kasparov narrowly retaining the title in each.[33]

Date	Location	Winner	Score	Runner-up	Format	Ref
1948†	The Hague (1–10), Moscow (11–20)	Mikhail Botvinnik	14 – 6[a]	Vasily Smyslov	Quintuple round-robin tournament with 5 players	[34]
1951‡	Moscow	Mikhail Botvinnik (2)	12 – 12	David Bronstein	Best of 24	[35]
1954‡		Mikhail Botvinnik (3)	12 – 12	Vasily Smyslov		[36]
1957		Vasily Smyslov	12½ – 9½	Mikhail Botvinnik		[37]
1958		Mikhail Botvinnik (4)	12½ – 10½	Vasily Smyslov		[37]
1960		Mikhail Tal	12½ – 8½	Mikhail Botvinnik		[38]
1961		Mikhail Botvinnik (5)	13 – 8	Mikhail Tal		[39]
1963		Tigran Petrosian	12½ – 9½	Mikhail Botvinnik		[40]
1966		Tigran Petrosian (2)	12½ – 11½	Boris Spassky		[41]
1969		Boris Spassky	12½ – 10½	Tigran Petrosian		[42]
1972	Reykjavík	Bobby Fischer	12½ – 8½	Boris Spassky		[43]
1975#	Manila	Anatoly Karpov	—	Bobby Fischer		[44]
1978	Baguio	Anatoly Karpov (2)	16½ – 15½	Viktor Korchnoi	First to 6 wins	[45]
1981	Merano	Anatoly Karpov (3)	11 – 7	Viktor Korchnoi		[46]
1984–1985✻	Moscow	Anatoly Karpov	25 – 23	Garry Kasparov		[47]
1985		Garry Kasparov	13 – 11	Anatoly Karpov	Best of 24	[48]
1986	London (1–12), Leningrad (13–24)	Garry Kasparov (2)	12½ – 11½	Anatoly Karpov		[49]
1987‡	Seville	Garry Kasparov (3)	12 – 12	Anatoly Karpov		[50]
1990	New York City (1–12), Lyon (13–24)	Garry Kasparov (4)	12½ – 11½	Anatoly Karpov		[51]

a. 3 – 2 Smyslov, 4 – 1 Keres, 3½ – 1½ Reshevsky, 3½ – 1½ Euwe

Split title (1993–2006)

In 1993, following Nigel Short's victory in the Candidates Tournament, FIDE president Campomanes announced that that year's Championship would take place in Manchester, England. Both Kasparov and Short claimed that FIDE had made this decision without consulting either player, in violation of FIDE's regulations regarding the championship. Kasparov and Short responded by splitting from FIDE and forming the Professional Chess Association (PCA),[52] which organized a World Championship match between the two, played in London later that year. Meanwhile, FIDE stripped Kasparov of his title and organized a championship match between Karpov and Jan Timman, who had finished second and third in the Candidates Tournament.[53] For the 13 years between 1993 and 2006, there were two rival titles. While the PCA itself would fold after only a couple of years, Kasparov would retain what is referred to as "Classical" title, which would be inherited by Vladimir Kramnik upon defeating Kasparov in 2000.[54]



Play between Garry Kasparov (left) and Viswanathan Anand (right) in the Top of the World observation deck of 2 World Trade Center during the 1995 PCA World Chess Championship

Meanwhile, FIDE once again began experimenting with the championship format. Beginning with the 1998 championship, the system of Zonal, Interzonal, Candidates, and Championship stages was replaced with one single-elimination tournament featuring dozens of players competing for the championship. For the next event in 1999, the incumbent World Champion would not automatically qualify for the finals. Due to this additional change, Karpov—who had won three additional titles during the schism—declined to participate going forward. Each of the four Classical Championships retained a traditional match format.[55]

Classical World Chess Championships (1993–2006)

Date	Location	Winner	Score	Runner-up	Format	Ref
1993	London	Garry Kasparov (5)	12½ – 7½	Nigel Short	Best of 24	[56]
1995	New York City	Garry Kasparov (6)	10½ – 7½	Viswanathan Anand	Best of 20	[57]
2000	London	Vladimir Kramnik	8½ – 6½	Garry Kasparov	Best of 16	[58]
2004‡	Brissago	Vladimir Kramnik (2)	7 – 7	Peter Leko	Best of 14	[59]

FIDE World Chess Championships (1993–2006)

Date	Location	Winner	Score	Runner-up	Format	Ref
1993	Zwolle (1–3), Arnhem (4–6), Amsterdam (7–12), Jakarta (13–24)	Anatoly Karpov (4)	12½–8½	Jan Timman	Best of 24	[60]
1996	Elista	Anatoly Karpov (5)	10½–7½	Gata Kamsky	Best of 20	[61]
1998†	Lausanne	Anatoly Karpov (6)	3–3 2–0 [a]	Viswanathan Anand	Single-elimination tournament with 100 players	[62]
1999†	Las Vegas	Alexander Khalifman	18½–11½ [b]	Vladimir Akopian		[63]
2000†	New Delhi (rounds 1–6), Tehran (round 7)	Viswanathan Anand	14–6 [c]	Alexei Shirov		[64]
2002†	Moscow	Ruslan Ponomariov	19–9 [d]	Vasyl Ivanchuk	Single-elimination tournament with 128 players	[65]
2004†	Tripoli	Rustam Kasimdzhanov	20–10 [e]	Michael Adams		[66]
2005†	Potrero de los Funes	Veselin Topalov	10–4 [f]	Viswanathan Anand	Double round-robin tournament with 8 players	[67]

a. Karpov was automatically seeded into the final round: a best of 6, with tiebreaks as needed.
b. 3½–2½ Barua, 2½–1½ Kamsky, 1½–½ Asrian, 2½–1½ Gelfand, 1½–½ Polgár, 3½–2½ Nisipeanu, 3½–2½ Akopian
c. Anand had a bye in the first round. 1½–½ Bologan, 1½–½ Lputian, 1½–½ Macieja, 3½–2½ Khalifman, 2½–1½ Adams, 3½–½ Shirov
d. 1½–½ Li, 3–1 Tiviakov, 2–0 Georgiev, 2½–1½ Morozevich, 3–1 Bareev, 2½–1½ Svidler, 4½–2½ Ivanchuk
e. 2½–1½ Ramírez, 1½–½ Ghaem Maghami, 2½–1½ Ivanchuk, 2–0 Almási, 3–1 Grischuk, 4–2 Topalov, 4½–3½ Adams
f. 1–1 Anand, 1½–½ Svidler, 1½–½ Morozevich, 1½–½ Leko, 1½–½ Kasimdzhanov, 1½–½ Adams, 1½–½ Polgár

FIDE World Championships (2006–present)

Following a period of negotiation, in 2006 the Classical Champion Vladimir Kramnik played a match against the FIDE Champion Veselin Topalov to reunify the World Championship.[68] Since then, the championship has remained under the auspices of FIDE. The Candidates Tournament returned, and with the exception of the 2007 tournament, FIDE would return to a match format for the World Championship. Instead of the previous system of Zonals and Interzonals to provide candidates, the system was redesigned around the Chess World Cup.[69] Later, means for selecting candidates would variously include the FIDE Grand Prix, the FIDE Grand Swiss Tournament, selection by rating, and wild cards selected by the venue hosting the event.[70]

While shorter matches had taken place at various points, the block of 12 classical games was much shorter than matches had been for much of the 20th century. In the 2018 match, all 12 classical games resulted in draws for the first time in the history of the championship. Following this, the number of games was increased to 14.[71] Citing a lack of motivation and interest in the format, incumbent five-time champion Magnus Carlsen declined to defend his title in 2023.[72] Instead, the match featured the two best performers in the Candidates, with Ding Liren defeating Ian Nepomniachtchi to become the new World Champion. Carlsen later declined his spot in the 2024 Candidates Tournament.[73]



Ian Nepomniachtchi (left) and Magnus Carlsen (right) beginning game 11 of the 2021 Championship

Date	Location	Winner	Score	Runner-up	Format	Ref
2006	Elista	Vladimir Kramnik (3)	6–6 2½–1½	Veselin Topalov	Best of 12, tiebreaks if necessary	[74]
2007†	Mexico City	Viswanathan Anand (2)	9–5 [a]	Vladimir Kramnik	Double round-robin tournament with 8 players	[75]
2008	Bonn	Viswanathan Anand (3)	6½–4½	Vladimir Kramnik	Best of 12, tiebreaks if necessary	[76]
2010	Sofia	Viswanathan Anand (4)	6½–5½	Veselin Topalov		[77]
2012	Moscow	Viswanathan Anand (5)	6–6 2½–1½	Boris Gelfand		[78]
2013	Chennai	Magnus Carlsen	6½–3½	Viswanathan Anand		[79]
2014	Sochi	Magnus Carlsen (2)	6½–4½	Viswanathan Anand		[80]
2016	New York City	Magnus Carlsen (3)	6–6 3–1	Sergey Karjakin		[81]
2018	London	Magnus Carlsen (4)	6–6 3–0	Fabiano Caruana		[82]
2021	Dubai	Magnus Carlsen (5)	7½–3½	Ian Nepomniachtchi	Best of 14, tiebreaks if necessary	[83]
2023	Astana	Ding Liren	7–7 2½–1½	Ian Nepomniachtchi		[84]
2024	Singapore	Gukesh Dommaraju	7½–6½	Ding Liren		[85]
2026	Geneva	Gukesh Dommaraju vs Javokhir Sindarov				

a. 1–1 Kramnik, 1–1 Gelfand, 1–1 Leko, 1½–½ Svidler, 1½–½ Morozevich, 1½–½ Aronian, 1½–½ Grischuk

Unrecognized championship events

In 1909, amid discussions that would ultimately culminate with the World Championship match played the following year, Emanuel Lasker played a casual match with Dawid Janowski in Paris. This was reported in later decades as being a World Championship match.[86] However, research by Edward Winter has demonstrated that the title was not at stake.[87]

Date	Location	Winner	Score	Runner-up	Format
1909	Paris	Emanuel Lasker	8 – 2	Dawid Janowski	Best of 10, casual play

See also

- List of strong chess tournaments
- Fischer–Spassky (1992 match) – rematch between Bobby Fischer and Boris Spassky in Belgrade 20 years after their first match, considered by Fischer to be and billed as a World Chess Championship. Fischer won 10–5, with 15 draws.

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